Food of the seventy-two seasons

WORKING GLOSSARY / FRUIT · VEGETABLES · FISH & SEAFOOD

235 distinct source labels from currently cached season letters. Every listed fruit, vegetable, and fish has a name, a short food note, and season cross-reference. Names, duplicate aliases, Japanese spellings, and catalogue-derived notes need editorial and source review before print.

82 ITEM STUDIES / TWO ON EACH OF 41 CATEGORY PAGES

DESIGN PROOF / IMAGE SUBJECTS AND COPY UNVERIFIED

Fruit

Akebi

木通 · あけび

akebi / KŌ 38

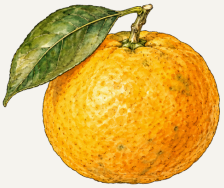
A wild vine fruit with pale lavender skin that cracks to reveal translucent, seed-studded flesh tasting faintly of honeydew and lychee, the soft interior is eaten fresh while the bitter rind is stuffed with miso-seasoned meat and fried.

01 Amanatsu orange

甘夏 · あまなつ

amanatsu / KŌ 27, 28

A thick-skinned hybrid citrus whose flesh delivers bright acidity tempered by a honeyed undertone, the bitterness of its pith prized for marmalades and candied peel.



01 / Amanatsu orange

Amanatsu

甘夏 · あまなつ

amanatsu / KŌ 22

A thick-skinned citrus whose flesh balances bright acidity with a honeyed sweetness that only emerges after months of patient storage past the winter harvest.

Amanatsu orange

甘夏 · あまなつ

amanatsu / KŌ 21, 25, 26

Harvested in winter but left to mellow until April or May, amanatsu trades sharpness for a honeyed acidity, its thick pith still carrying enough pleasant bitterness to wake the palate.

02 / Asian persimmon

02 Asian persimmon

柿 · かき

kaki / KŌ 53

The hachiya variety yields to the slightest pressure when truly ripe, its flesh collapsing into a honeylike sweetness that tastes faintly of cinnamon and dates.

Fruit

Loquat

枇杷 · びわ

biwa / KŌ 29, 30, 32, 34

Beneath thin, tawny skin lies flesh the color of pale apricot, yielding and faintly perfumed, with a sweetness that recalls honey warmed by afternoon sun.

01 / Loquat

01 Loquat

枇杷 · びわ

biwa / KŌ 23

These early loquats arrive with skin still pale orange and flesh that yields a bright, faintly tart sweetness, not yet the honeyed depth of peak season, but refreshing as a first sip of something cold.

Loquat

枇杷 · びわ

biwa / KŌ 22

These early loquats arrive with skin still pale orange and flesh that yields a bright, faintly tart sweetness, not yet the honeyed depth of peak season, but refreshing as a first sip of something cold.

Blueberry

ブルーベリー

burūberī / KŌ 36

Japanese blueberries grown in highland orchards reach their sweetest point in July and August, their skins taut with a bloom of pale dust that smudges at the touch.

Japanese grape

葡萄 · ぶどう

budō / KŌ 41

Japanese grapes like Kyoho and Shine Muscat are prized for flesh that slips clean from the skin, intensely sweet with a musky depth that fills the mouth.

02 Cherry

桜桃 · おうとう

ōtō / KŌ 33

Japanese cherries arrive with flesh so tender it yields at the slightest pressure, their sweetness balanced by a faint tartness that lingers on the tongue.

02 / Cherry

Fruit

Cherry

桜桃 · おうとう

ōtō / KŌ 24

These earliest cherries arrive with flesh still firm and flavor caught between sweet and tart, a brightness that speaks of orchards not yet heavy with full summer.

01 Early peach

早桃 · はやもも

hayamomo / KŌ 33

The first peaches of the season arrive smaller and firmer than their midsummer kin, their flesh yielding a clean, almost floral sweetness that carries a whisper of tartness near the stone.

01 / Early peach

Early pear

早生梨 · わせなし

wase nashi / KŌ 40

These first nashi of the season arrive with flesh so crisp it shatters against the teeth, their juice running clear and faintly honeyed before the deeper sweetness of later harvests develops.

Early persimmon

早柿 · はやがき

hayagaki / KŌ 50

These first persimmons of the season arrive while summer's heat still lingers, their flesh firm and crisp rather than the jammy softness of later varieties, a clean sweetness with faint astringency at the edges.

Persimmon

柿 · かき

kaki / KŌ 47

These early-harvest persimmons arrive while still carrying a faint astringency, their flesh firm enough to slice cleanly, revealing that particular orange that seems to hold the last warmth of summer.

02 / Fig

02 Fig

無花果 · いちじく

ichijiku / KŌ 47

The flesh yields to the teeth in a way that feels almost liquid, honey-sweet with a faint graininess from the countless tiny seeds within.

Fruit

Fig
無花果 · いちじく

ichijiku / KŌ 49

The flesh yields to the teeth with almost no resistance, a soft collapse into honeyed sweetness, the tiny seeds adding just enough texture to remind you this is fruit, not confection.

01 / Green plum

01 Green plum
青梅 · あおうめ

aoume / KŌ 24

Hard, astringent, and intensely fragrant, green plums arrive too sour to eat raw, their purpose is transformation.

Strawberry
苺 · いちご

ichigo / KŌ 22

Japanese strawberries are bred for sweetness over tartness, their flesh yielding and fragrant, often eaten unadorned or perched atop shortcake in pristine rows.

Japanese pear
梨 · なし

nashi / KŌ 44, 46, 47, 50

Unlike its Western cousins, nashi offers a crisp, granular flesh that shatters between the teeth with a spray of cool, faintly floral juice, refreshment distilled into fruit form.

02 Kabosu
香母酢 · かぼす

kabosu / KŌ 48

A golf ball-sized citrus from Ōita Prefecture, kabosu yields a juice more rounded than sudachi, less bitter than lemon, its pale green flesh releasing an aroma somewhere between bergamot and fresh-cut grass when squeezed over grilled sanma.

02 / Kabosu

Persimmon
柿 · かき

kaki / KŌ 54, 55, 56

The hachiya variety yields to gentle pressure when perfectly ripe, its flesh collapsing into a honey-thick pulp that tastes of dates and brown sugar with a faint tannic whisper.

Fruit

Persimmon

柿 · かき

kaki / KŌ 51

Early varieties like Saijo and Nishimura-wase offer a firm, almost crisp flesh with a honeyed sweetness that intensifies after a light frost, the astringency of unripe fruit transformed into something purely clean.

01 Chinese quince

花梨 · かりん

karin / KŌ 55

Too hard and astringent to eat raw, the golden karin is prized for its intoxicating fragrance, a honeyed sweetness that fills winter rooms when placed in a bowl.

01 / Chinese quince

02 / Koshu grape

02 Koshu grape

甲州葡萄 · こうしゅうぶどう

kōshū budō / KŌ 54

Japan's indigenous wine grape, cultivated in the foothills of Mount Fuji for over a millennium, with translucent pink-bronze skin that yields flesh of gentle sweetness and a faint mineral finish.

Kosui pear

幸水 · こうすい

kōsui / KŌ 49

The first major nashi of the season, Kōsui arrives with flesh so crisp it shatters against the teeth, releasing juice that tastes of honey touched with the faintest citrus acidity.

Kurinameshi pear

栗南水 · くりなめし

kurinameshi / KŌ 56

A newer nashi cultivar bred for exceptional sweetness and dense, fine-grained flesh that shatters cleanly between the teeth, its juice running clear as spring water.

Black soybean pickles

黒豆漬け · くろまめずけ

kuromame-zuke / KŌ 54

Glossy black soybeans simmered until tender, then steeped in sweetened soy until each bean holds a lacquered sheen and faint molasses depth.

Fruit

01 / Kyoho grape

01 Kyoho grape

巨峰 · きょほう

kyohō / KŌ 46, 47, 52

These dark purple grapes slip from their skins with a gentle squeeze, revealing translucent flesh so sweet and musky it perfumes the fingers.

Late strawberry

晩生苺 · ばんせいいちご

bansei ichigo / KŌ 24

These final strawberries of the season arrive smaller and deeply flushed, their sugars concentrated by warming days into an almost jammy intensity that the pale spring berries never achieve.

Loquat

枇杷 · びわ

biwa / KŌ 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 33, 35

Beneath its thin, downy skin lies flesh the color of apricot preserve, yielding, faintly tart, with a floral sweetness that vanishes almost as quickly as it arrives.

Loquat

枇杷 · びわ

biwa / KŌ 21

Beneath thin, suede-like skin lies flesh the color of apricot sunset, faintly tart, honeyed, with a floral finish that dissolves on the tongue.

02 Mango

マンゴー

mangō / KŌ 36

Miyazaki's Taiyo no Tamago mangoes arrive with flesh so dense and perfumed it yields like custard beneath the knife, their skin blushing from green to sunset red.

02 / Mango

Mango

マンゴー

mangō / KŌ 30

Okinawan mangoes, predominantly the Irwin variety, are harvested only after they drop naturally into nets suspended beneath the trees, their flesh a deep saffron, almost custardy, with a fragrance that fills a room before the knife touches skin.

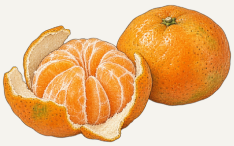
Fruit

01 Mikan

晩生みかん · ばんせいみかん

bansei mikan / KŌ 21

These late-ripening satsuma mandarins have thicker skins and denser flesh than their autumn cousins, their sweetness deepened by months of winter chill into something almost honeyed.



01 / Mikan

Peach

桃 · もも

momo / KŌ 31

These early peaches arrive with flesh still pale and firm, their sweetness restrained, carrying a faint astringency that softens only after a day on the kitchen counter.

White peach

白桃 · もも

momo / KŌ 36, 41

The white peach yields to the slightest pressure, its flesh so delicate it bruises at a glance, the juice runs clear and fragrant, tasting of flowers more than fruit.

Mountain yam bulbil

零余子 · むかご

mukago / KŌ 55

These thumbnail-sized aerial tubers form where leaf meets stem on the wild yamanoimo vine, their thin russet skin yielding to a faintly sticky, nutty flesh when roasted in their jackets with coarse salt.

Muscat grape

マスカット

masukatto / KŌ 44

Shine Muscat grapes arrive with skins so thin you eat them whole, their flesh crisp and perfumed with a sweetness that tastes almost of white flowers.

02 / Muscat grape

02 Muscat grape

マスカット

masukatto / KŌ 38, 49, 53

Japanese Shine Muscat grapes yield to the teeth with a crisp snap, their translucent jade flesh releasing a perfume somewhere between lychee and white flowers, eaten skin and all, no seeds to interrupt the pleasure.

Fruit

Asian pear

梨 · なし

nashi / KŌ 41, 43, 54

Unlike its Western cousin, the nashi yields a spray of cold, granular juice the moment teeth break skin, more refreshing than sweet, like biting into autumn itself.

Summer orange

夏蜜柑 · なつみかん

natsu mikan / KŌ 22, 23

A thick-skinned citrus with segments that pull apart in uneven petals, its juice bracingly acidic with a faint honeyed finish that arrives only after months of patience on the branch.

Nijisseiki pear

二十世紀梨 · にじっせいきなし

nijisseiki nashi / KŌ 45, 48

A thin-skinned pear with jade-pale flesh so crisp it shatters between the teeth, releasing a flood of juice sweet as spring water.

Nijisseiki pear

二十世紀梨 · にじっせいきなし

nijisseiki nashi / KŌ 51

Named 'twentieth century' for a future that has now become nostalgia, this pale jade sphere yields flesh so water-laden it seems to dissolve on the tongue, its sweetness restrained, almost austere.

01 / Passion fruit

01 Passion fruit

パッションフルーツ

passhon furūtsu / KŌ 40

Cut crosswise, the wrinkled purple shell reveals a glistening cavity of black seeds suspended in translucent golden pulp, intensely aromatic, at once tart and honeyed, with a fragrance that fills the room.

02 Japanese pear

梨 · なし

nashi / KŌ 52, 53

Unlike its Western cousin, the nashi offers a crisp, granular flesh that shatters between the teeth, its juice running cool and faintly honeyed with none of the butter-soft yield of European varieties.

02 / Japanese pear

Fruit

Persimmon

柿 · かき

kaki / KŌ 52

Early varieties like Saijo and Hiratanenashi arrive while summer's warmth lingers, their flesh still firm with a delicate sweetness that has not yet deepened to honey.

Pione grape

ピオーネ

piōne / KŌ 43, 44, 45, 46, 51

A cross between Kyoho and Cannon Hall Muscat, Pione yields berries the size of small plums with blue-black skin that slips away to reveal translucent flesh of startling sweetness and faint musk.

Pione grape

ピオーネ

piōne / KŌ 48, 49, 50

A cross between Kyoho and Cannon Hall Muscat, Pione grapes carry the deep purple-black bloom of their parent with flesh that slips cleanly from the skin, each orb bursting with concentrated sweetness balanced by faint acidity.

01 **Prune plum**

西洋李 · せいようすもも

seiyō sumomo / KŌ 34

These oval European plums arrive with flesh that yields to honey-sweetness, their skins carrying that particular dusty bloom that rubs away under the thumb.

01 / Prune plum

02 / Apple

02 **Apple**

林檎 · りんご

ringo / KŌ 56

Japanese apples arrive large and impeccably crisp, their flesh shattering cleanly under the teeth with a spray of juice that carries both sweetness and a faint wine-like depth.

Fruit

Cherry

桜桃 · さくらんぼ

sakuranbo / KŌ 31, 32, 35

These are not the ornamental cherries of hanami but eating varieties, Satonishiki with their heart-shaped bodies yielding flesh that snaps clean and sweet against the teeth.

Cherry

桜桃 · さくらんぼ

sakuranbo / KŌ 28, 29, 30

These first cherries arrive small and taut-skinned, their flesh snapping with a brightness that leans more toward tartness than the honeyed depth of later harvests.

01 / Shine Muscat grape

Shine Muscat grape

シャインマスカット

shain masukatto / KŌ 48, 50

A seedless grape with skin so thin you eat it whole, each orb bursting with a honeyed sweetness that carries faint notes of muscat and citrus blossom.

01 Shine Muscat grape

シャインマスカット

shain masukatto / KŌ 45, 51

A seedless grape with skin so thin it yields without resistance, releasing flesh that tastes of muscat perfume and white honey.

02 Strawberry

苺 · いちご

ichigo / KŌ 23, 25, 26, 27

Japanese strawberries are bred for delicate sweetness and tender flesh, varieties like Amaou and Tochiotome prized for their fragrance and jewel-like appearance on white porcelain.

02 / Strawberry

Strawberry

苺 · いちご

ichigo / KŌ 21

Japanese strawberries are bred for sweetness over tartness, their flesh so tender it bruises at a careless touch, varieties like Amaou and Tochiotome yield berries with a perfumed intensity that fills the room when sliced.

Fruit

Sudachi

酢橘 · すだち

sudachi / KŌ 40

A small citrus no larger than a golf ball, prized not for eating whole but for its intensely aromatic juice, a few drops over grilled sanma or matsutake bring the umami into sudden, bright focus.

01 Sudachi

酢橘 · すだち

sudachi / KŌ 56

A small citrus no larger than a golf ball, prized not for its flesh but for its intensely aromatic rind and bracingly sour juice, a few drops transform grilled sanma or matsutake soup with bright, clean acidity.

01 / Sudachi

Sudachi

酢橘 · すだち

sudachi / KŌ 43, 52, 53

A small citrus no larger than a golf ball, prized not for its flesh but for its intensely aromatic rind and bracingly sour juice, a few drops transform grilled sanma or matsutake soup with bright, clean acidity.

02 / Watermelon

02 Watermelon

西瓜 · すいか

suika / KŌ 31, 32, 35

These early specimens arrive smaller and denser than their midsummer cousins, their flesh a concentrated pink with a crispness that yields cleanly to the teeth.

Watermelon

西瓜 · すいか

suika / KŌ 29

The season's first watermelons arrive with flesh still pale at the edges, their sweetness restrained and clean, a coolness you taste before you feel.

Watermelon

西瓜 · すいか

suika / KŌ 34, 41

The flesh should give way with an audible crack when split, its sweetness concentrated where the seeds cluster darkest near the rind.

Fruit

Japanese plum

李 · すもも

sumomo / KŌ 36

Smaller and rounder than its Western cousins, the sumomo offers flesh that ranges from honey-gold to deep crimson, with a tartness at the skin that yields to syrupy sweetness near the stone.

01 / Green plum

01 **Green plum**

青梅 · あおうめ

aoume / KŌ 30, 34

Hard, intensely sour, and fragrant with a sharp green perfume, these unripe plums are never eaten raw but transformed through salt or sugar into umeboshi and umeshu.

Green plum

青梅 · あおうめ

aoume / KŌ 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 31, 32, 35

Hard, astringent, and intensely fragrant, green plums arrive too sour to eat raw, their flesh meant instead for transformation into umeshu liqueur or the salt-preserved umeboshi that will sustain appetites through humid months ahead.

Green plum

青梅 · あおうめ

aoume / KŌ 23

Hard, astringent, and intensely fragrant, green plums arrive too sour to eat raw, their sharp vegetal scent fills the kitchen as they wait to be transformed into umeshu or umeboshi.

02 **Watermelon**

西瓜 · すいか

suika / KŌ 38

The flesh should give way with an audible crack when split, its sweetness concentrated in the pale heart where seeds cluster darkest.

02 / Watermelon

White peach

白桃 · はくとう

hakutō / KŌ 38, 40, 45

Cradled in foam nets at fruit shops, these pale beauties yield flesh so tender it bruises at a glance, their perfume filling a room before the first bite releases floods of honeyed juice.

Fruit

White peach
白桃 · はくとう

hakutō / KŌ 43, 44, 46

Cradled in foam nets at fruit shops, these pale beauties yield flesh so tender it bruises at a glance, their perfume filling a room before the first bite releases floods of honeyed juice.

01 Wild mountain grape
山葡萄 · やまぶど

yamabudo / KŌ 55

These small, intensely flavored grapes grow wild on vines that climb forest trees, their deep purple-black clusters yielding a juice so tart and concentrated it stains the tongue.

01 / Wild mountain grape

02 / Ripe plum

02 Ripe plum
完熟梅 · かんじゅくうめ

kanjuku ume / KŌ 33

These are ume left on the branch until they blush gold and yield to gentle pressure, their flesh now fragrant with apricot-like sweetness rather than the sharp green astringency of earlier pickings.

Watermelon
西瓜 · すいか

suika / KŌ 42

The flesh should give way with an audible crack when split, its sweetness concentrated where the seeds cluster darkest near the rind.

Grape
葡萄 · ぶどう

budō / KŌ 42

Japanese grapes arrive heavy on the stem, their skins slipping free to reveal flesh so sweet it borders on floral, varieties like Kyoho and Shine Muscat prized for size, fragrance, and that first cold bite.

Blueberry
ブルーベリー

burūberī / KŌ 37, 39

Japanese blueberries grown in highland orchards reach their sweetest point in July and August, their skins taut with a bloom of pale dust that smudges at the touch.

Fruit

01 / Plum

01 Plum
プラム
puramu / KŌ 37, 39

These Western-style plums arrive with flesh that yields to the tooth in a single clean give, their skins taut and blushed from deep garnet to pale gold, each variety balancing tart snap against honeyed sweetness.

Mango
マンゴー
mangō / KŌ 39

Miyazaki's Taiyo no Tamago mangoes arrive with flesh so dense and perfumed it yields like custard beneath the knife, their skin blushing from green to sunset red.

White peach
桃 · もも
momo / KŌ 37, 39

Japanese white peaches yield to the slightest pressure, their pale flesh so juicy it must be eaten over the sink, fragrant with a sweetness that seems to hold the whole of summer afternoons.

02 Japanese pear
梨 · なし
nashi / KŌ 42

Unlike Western pears, nashi yields a crisp, granular flesh that shatters between the teeth, its juice cool and faintly floral, chilled slices served after dinner carry the first relief of cooler nights.

02 / Japanese pear

White peach
白桃 · はくとう
hakutō / KŌ 42

Cradled in foam nets at fruit shops, these pale beauties yield flesh so tender it bruises at a glance, their perfume filling a room before the first bite releases floods of honeyed juice.

Watermelon
西瓜 · すいか
suika / KŌ 37

The flesh should give way with an audible crack when split, its sweetness concentrated in the pale heart where seeds cluster darkest.

Vegetables

Green yuzu

青柚子 · あおゆず

aoyuzu / KŌ 34

Harvested unripe, green yuzu offers a sharper, more herbaceous bite than its mature form, the zest bright with volatile oils that sting the nose pleasantly when grated over warm dishes.

Ashitaba

明日葉 · あしたば

ashitaba / KŌ 26

A coastal herb from the Izu Islands whose thick stems weep golden sap when cut, the flavor sits between celery and angelica, with a faint medicinal bitterness that tempura transforms into something almost sweet.

01 Bamboo shoot

筍 · たけのこ

takenoko / KŌ 24, 25, 27

Dug at dawn before the sun can turn their sugars bitter, fresh takenoko have a faint sweetness and a texture that yields with a clean snap, nothing like the pallid canned version.

01 / Bamboo shoot

Bamboo shoot

筍 · たけのこ

takenoko / KŌ 21

Freshly dug takenoko must reach the pot within hours, before its sugars turn to woody bitterness; the flesh should taste faintly sweet, with a clean vegetal snap unlike anything that has traveled far.

02 / Bitter melon

02 Bitter melon

苦瓜 · にがうり

nigauri / KŌ 38, 40

The warted jade skin yields to a spongy, pale interior whose bracing bitterness cuts through the humidity like a cold cloth on the neck.

Vegetables

Bitter melon

苦瓜 · ごうや

gōya / KŌ 43

This ridged, warty gourd yields flesh of startling bitterness, a quality prized precisely because it cools the body and sharpens the appetite when humid air sits heavy on the skin.

Edamame

枝豆 · えだまめ

edamame / KŌ 33, 34, 35, 40, 46

Young soybeans harvested still clinging to the branch, their pods furred with fine hairs that hold the morning dew; bite through and the beans slide out with a faint sweetness, tasting of green growth and salt.

01 / Fava bean

Fava bean

空豆 · そらまめ

soramame / KŌ 21

Named 'sky beans' for the way their pods point upward before harvest, soramame offer a fleeting sweetness best captured within three days of picking, grilled in their pods until charred, the beans inside turn creamy with a faint grassy brightness.

01 Fava bean

空豆 · そらまめ

soramame / KŌ 24, 25, 27, 28

Called 'sky beans' for the way their pods point upward on the stem, these legumes arrive with a fleeting sweetness and grass-green fragrance that disappears within days of harvest.

02 Butterbur

蕗 · ふき

fuki / KŌ 22, 23

Pale green stems with a mineral bitterness that lingers clean on the tongue, their hollow centers ideal for simmering in dashi until the fibers turn silken.

02 / Butterbur

Vegetables

Ginkgo nut

銀杏 · ぎんなん

ginnan / KŌ 52

These jade-green kernels hide beneath a notoriously pungent flesh, their flavor somewhere between chestnut and edamame with a faintly bitter, almost resinous finish.

Ginkgo nut

銀杏 · ぎんなん

ginnan / KŌ 48

Beneath their notoriously pungent flesh, these jade-green kernels offer a texture between chestnut and edamame, with a faint bitterness that deepens when skewered and salt-grilled over charcoal.

Ginkgo nut

銀杏 · ぎんなん

ginnan / KŌ 50

These jade-green kernels, encased in shells that crack with a satisfying pop, carry a faintly bitter, almost piney sweetness and a texture between chestnut and pine nut.

Ginkgo nut

銀杏 · ぎんなん

ginnan / KŌ 53

Jade-colored kernels with a faintly resinous, bittersweet taste and a texture that yields like a firm cheese between the teeth.

01 Ginkgo nut

銀杏 · ぎんなん

ginnan / KŌ 55

The pale jade kernels, freed from their pungent husks, offer a waxy bite and faint bitterness that carries the mineral taste of late autumn.

01 / Ginkgo nut

02 / Burdock root

02 Burdock root

牛蒡 · ごぼう

gobō / KŌ 56

A slender, earth-colored root with bark-rough skin and flesh that oxidizes to pale rust the moment it meets air; prized for its dense, almost meaty chew and faint sweetness that emerges after long simmering.

Vegetables

01 / Green pea

01 Green pea

青豌豆 · あおえんどう

ao-endō / KŌ 26

Freshly shelled peas possess a sweetness that fades within hours of harvest, their sugars converting to starch even as you carry them home.

Green shiso

青紫蘇 · あおしそ

aoshiso / KŌ 33, 35

The jagged leaves release their unmistakable fragrance only when torn or bruised, a sharp, almost mentholated freshness that cuts through the heaviness of raw fish and summer heat.

Green shiso

大葉 · おおば

ōba / KŌ 47

These broad, serrated leaves release a bright, almost electric fragrance when torn, part mint, part basil, part something wilder that belongs only to itself.

Napa cabbage

白菜 · はくさい

hakusai / KŌ 54

Broad, pale leaves with crisp white ribs that turn silken when braised, their flavor deepening to a subtle sweetness after the first hard frost transforms their starches.

Japanese sweet potato

薩摩芋 · さつまいも

satsumaimo / KŌ 50

The flesh beneath its purple-red skin turns from pale yellow to deep gold when roasted slowly, releasing a caramelized sweetness that needs nothing more.

02 Yard-long bean

十六ささげ · じゅうろくささげ

jūroku sasage / KŌ 41

Named for the sixteen seeds that line each slender pod, these beans snap with a grassy sweetness and cook to a silken texture that green beans cannot match.

02 / Yard-long bean

Vegetables

Kabocha

南瓜 · かぼちゃ

kabocha / KŌ 43, 45

A dense-fleshed winter squash with dry, chestnut-like sweetness and skin tender enough to eat, the flesh turns almost jam-thick when simmered in dashi and soy.

01 Kabocha squash

南瓜 · かぼちゃ

kabocha / KŌ 46, 47

A dense-fleshed winter squash with deep green rind and flesh the color of persimmon, prized for its chestnut-like sweetness that intensifies in storage.

01 / Kabocha squash

Turnip

蕪 · かぶ

kabu / KŌ 56

The Japanese turnip is smaller and more delicate than its Western counterpart, with skin so thin it need not be peeled and flesh that turns silken when simmered in dashi.

Cucumber

胡瓜 · きゅうり

kyūri / KŌ 31

Japanese cucumbers arrive slender and thin-skinned, their flesh dense with a grassy sweetness that shatters cleanly between the teeth, nothing like their waterlogged Western cousins.

02 / Lotus root

02 Lotus root

蓮根 · れんこん

renkon / KŌ 38, 45, 49

Cut crosswise, the wheel reveals its lace of air pockets, a pattern read as 'seeing clearly into the future,' making it essential to New Year's osechi.

Lotus root

蓮根 · れんこん

renkon / KŌ 53

Sliced crosswise, each round reveals a wheel of hollow chambers, a pattern the Japanese read as 'seeing through to the future,' making it essential to New Year's osechi boxes.

Vegetables

01 / Maitake

01 Maitake

舞茸 · まいたけ

maitake / KŌ 45

Found clustered at the base of old oaks and chestnuts, maitake unfolds in rippling bronze-gray fronds with an earthy fragrance and a texture that stays toothsome whether grilled with a brush of soy or torn into tempura batter.

Manganji pepper

万願寺とうがらし · まんがんじとうがらし

manganji tōgarashi / KŌ 43

A long, thick-fleshed sweet pepper from Maizuru, Kyoto, virtually without heat, its skin blisters and chars beautifully over flame, releasing a green sweetness that tastes of summer rain on warm soil.

Manganji pepper

万願寺唐辛子 · まんがんじとうがらし

manganji tōgarashi / KŌ 35

These long, slender peppers from Maizuru carry almost no heat, just a grassy sweetness and skin so thin it blisters in seconds over high flame, releasing a faint char perfume.

Matsutake

松茸 · まつたけ

matsutake / KŌ 51, 54

This dense, ivory-fleshed mushroom releases a fragrance unlike any other, spicy, almost cinnamon-like, with an undertone of wet forest floor that perfumers have tried and failed to capture.

02 Matsutake mushroom

松茸 · まつたけ

matsutake / KŌ 49, 50, 52, 53

Found beneath fallen needles in ancient pine groves, this dense-fleshed mushroom releases a scent like cinnamon and cypress that no other fungus possesses, sliced thin and grilled over charcoal, it needs only a whisper of sudachi citrus.

02 / Matsutake mushroom

Matsutake mushroom

松茸 · まつたけ

matsutake / KŌ 48

Emerging from the duff beneath aged red pines, matsutake releases a scent both spicy and resinous, somewhere between cinnamon bark and wet stone, that no other mushroom possesses.

Vegetables

Japanese wild parsley

三つ葉 · みつば

mitsuba / KŌ 24

Three-lobed leaves on hollow stems carry a fragrance somewhere between celery and angelica, bright and faintly peppery, releasing their scent the moment they meet hot broth.

Japanese wild parsley

三つ葉 · みつば

mitsuba / KŌ 49

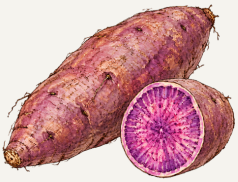
Three-leaved stems with a celery-bright bite and faint anise whisper, prized for their snap when floated raw atop clear soups or scattered over chawanmushi at the final moment.

01 Purple sweet potato

紫芋 · むらさきいも

murasaki-imo / KŌ 54

A dense, dry-fleshed sweet potato whose violet flesh deepens to near-indigo when steamed, yielding a chestnut-like sweetness with faint wine notes.



01 / Purple sweet potato

Japanese ginger

茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 35, 36

These pale pink buds emerge from the soil with a sharp, clean fragrance, sliced thin, they cut through the heaviness of summer with their peppery bite and subtle resin.

02 / Myoga ginger

02 Myoga ginger

茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 34

The pale pink bud of a wild ginger relative, sliced into threads that release a clean, resinous bite, bright against cold sōmen or scattered over chilled tofu.

Myoga ginger

茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 29, 30, 31, 32

These pale pink torpedo-shaped buds carry a bright, resinous sting that cuts through the heaviness of humid days, sliced thin, they shatter against cold sōmen or float in clear soup.

Vegetables

Myoga ginger
茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 41, 43, 44, 46

The pale pink buds of this shade-loving ginger offer a clean, resinous bite that cuts through humidity-dulled appetites, sliced thin, they float in chilled sōmen broth or crown a block of cold tofu.

Myōga ginger
茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 33

These torpedo-shaped flower buds carry a bright, resinous bite that cuts through summer's humidity, sliced thin, they dissolve into cold sōmen or scatter across chilled tofu like pink-tinged shards of clarity.

Myōga shoot
茗荷竹 · みょうがたけ

myōgatake / KŌ 28

These blanched young stems of the myōga ginger plant emerge before the familiar flower buds, offering a milder, more delicate bite, crisp as celery, faintly perfumed, often sliced thin for clear soups or dressed simply with miso.

01 / Mōi cucumber

01 Mōi cucumber
モーウィ

mōi / KŌ 44

A pale, thick-skinned heirloom cucumber from Okinawa with crisp, almost melon-like flesh that stays cool and firm even in brutal subtropical heat.

Eggplant
茄子 · なす

nasu / KŌ 29

The season's first eggplants arrive with thin, delicate skins and flesh so fine it barely resists the tooth, nothing like the dense globes of late summer.

02 Eggplant
茄子 · なす

nasu / KŌ 31, 32, 36

The skin turns glossy purple-black, stretched taut over cream-colored flesh that collapses into silk when grilled over charcoal.

02 / Eggplant

Vegetables

01 New garlic

新大蒜 · しんにんにく

shin ninniku / KŌ 28

Harvested young, new garlic offers a mild sweetness and moisture absent from cured heads, the cloves almost creamy when roasted whole, without the sharp bite that builds through storage.

01 / New garlic

New ginger

新生姜 · しんしょうが

shin shōga / KŌ 24, 25, 26

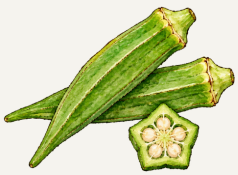
Pale as winter moonlight with tips blushed pink, new ginger arrives with flesh so delicate and fibers so fine it can be sliced tissue-thin and eaten raw, its heat bright but fleeting on the tongue.

New potato

新じゃが · しんじゃが

shin-jaga / KŌ 27, 30

Harvested before their skins have set, new potatoes possess a waxy, almost translucent flesh and a sweetness that dissipates within days of digging.



02 / Okra

02 Okra

オクラ

okura / KŌ 36, 40

Cut crosswise, each pod reveals a perfect five-pointed star, its mucilaginous threads binding dashi and soy into something cool and slippery against the August heat.

Vegetables

Rakkyo

辣韮 · らっきょう

rakkyō / KŌ 29

These small, ivory bulbs, somewhere between shallot and garlic in pungency, are harvested just as humidity settles over the archipelago, their crisp bite a natural foil for rich summer dishes.

Rakkyo

辣韮 · らっきょう

rakkyō / KŌ 30

Small, ivory bulbs with a sharp bite somewhere between shallot and garlic, harvested before the humidity settles in.

Lotus root

蓮根 · れんこん

renkon / KŌ 51

Sliced crosswise, its lacework of air pockets holds dashi or vinegar in every chamber, the crunch stays bright even after simmering.

Mountain vegetables

山菜 · さんさい

sansai / KŌ 22, 27

A collective term for wild edibles foraged from mountain and woodland, fiddlehead ferns, butterbur buds, fatsia shoots, each carrying its own bright bitterness that wakes the palate from winter's heaviness.

01 / Japanese pepper leaf

01 Japanese pepper leaf

山椒 · さんしょう

sanshō / KŌ 23

These young leaves carry a bright, almost electric tingle on the tongue, with a citrus-pine fragrance that cuts through rich dishes like simmered bamboo shoot or grilled eel.

02 Taro root

里芋 · さといも

satoimo / KŌ 48, 54, 55

These small, hairy corms yield flesh so slippery it seems to refuse the chopsticks, a quality called nameraka, prized in simmered dishes where the silken texture absorbs dashi to its core.

02 / Taro root

Vegetables

Taro

里芋 · さといも

satoimo / KŌ 56

The flesh yields to the teeth with a dense, almost glutinous give, its surface faintly slick from mucilage that speaks of the wet paddies where it grew.

01 Shimeji mushroom

しめじ

shimeji / KŌ 55

These slender clusters of buff-capped mushrooms release a faint nuttiness when heated, their crisp stems yielding to a texture somewhere between snap and silk.

01 / Shimeji mushroom

Shimeji mushroom

占地 · しめじ

shimeji / KŌ 47, 50, 51, 53

These tight clusters of slender stems and small brown caps carry a faint bitterness that sweetens only with heat, releasing an umami depth prized in nabemono and takikomi gohan.

Shimeji mushroom

占地 · しめじ

shimeji / KŌ 48

These clustered mushrooms grow in tight bundles, their small buff-colored caps firm and slightly bitter when raw, turning silken and faintly nutty once heat unlocks their umami.

02 / Shishito pepper

02 Shishito pepper

獅子唐 · ししとう

shishitō / KŌ 45, 46

Named for the wrinkled tip that resembles a lion's head, these thin-walled peppers blister quickly in hot oil, collapsing into tender pockets of grassy sweetness with an occasional surprising bite of heat, perhaps one in ten carries real fire.

Shishito pepper

獅子唐 · ししとう

shishitō / KŌ 44

Thin-skinned and mostly mild, these wrinkled fingers of pepper blister quickly in a hot pan, their flesh collapsing into something sweet and faintly smoky, though one in ten carries an unexpected bite of heat that keeps the eater alert.

Vegetables

Perilla

紫蘇 · しそ

shiso / KŌ 32

The deeply serrated leaves release a bright, almost electric fragrance when torn, part basil, part mint, part something entirely its own, cutting through the richness of raw fish or fried foods.

01 / Perilla

01 Perilla

紫蘇 · しそ

shiso / KŌ 29

Each leaf carries a sharp, almost medicinal brightness, part mint, part basil, part something wilder, that cuts through the humidity of summer meals, wrapped around sashimi or torn into cold somen.

Perilla

紫蘇 · しそ

shiso / KŌ 31, 34

Each leaf carries a bright, almost mentholated sharpness that cuts through the humidity of rainy season, wrap one around a bite of sashimi and the fish tastes cleaner, cooler.

Shiso

紫蘇 · しそ

shiso / KŌ 30, 38, 40

These jagged, aromatic leaves carry a flavor somewhere between mint and basil, with a faint citrus edge that cuts through the heaviness of rich foods.

02 Chrysanthemum greens

春菊 · しゅんぎく

shungiku / KŌ 52, 56

These serrated leaves carry a bracing, almost medicinal bitterness and a floral musk that cuts through rich broths, the reason they appear in hot pots just as the first real chill settles in.

02 / Chrysanthemum greens

Garland chrysanthemum

春菊 · しゅんぎく

shungiku / KŌ 51, 55

These serrated leaves carry a bracing, almost medicinal bitterness softened by an unexpected floral sweetness, their tender stems snapping cleanly between the teeth.

Vegetables

01 Silk pod pea

絹さや · きぬさや

kinusaya / KŌ 28

These flat, edible-podded peas earn their name from the silken sheen of their pale green skin, so thin it seems to hold light.

01 / Silk pod pea

Fava bean

空豆 · そらまめ

soramame / KŌ 23

Named 'sky beans' for their upward-reaching pods, soramame are best eaten the day they're picked, when their jade-green flesh holds a grassy sweetness that fades within hours.

02 / Spring cabbage

02 Spring cabbage

春キャベツ · はるきゃべつ

haru kyabetsu / KŌ 25, 26

Unlike the tight, pale heads of winter, spring cabbage arrives with leaves so tender they tear like wet paper, their sweetness bright enough to eat raw with nothing but a drift of salt.

Spring cabbage

春キャベツ · はるきゃべつ

haru kyabetsu / KŌ 21

Looser-headed than winter varieties, with pale yellow-green leaves so tender they're eaten raw in ribbons alongside tonkatsu, their sweetness bright and almost grassy.

Summer daikon

夏大根 · なつだいこん

natsu daikon / KŌ 33

Unlike the mild, sweet daikon of winter, summer daikon carries a peppery sting that cuts through humid days, grated raw, it becomes a cooling condiment with real presence.

Sweet potato

薩摩芋 · さつまいも

satsumaimo / KŌ 47

Freshly dug sweet potatoes need weeks of curing before their dense, chestnut-like flesh develops the honeyed sweetness that caramelizes at the edges of a stone-roasted imo.

Vegetables

Bamboo shoot

筍 · たけのこ

takenoko / KŌ 22, 23

Freshly dug shoots, still pale and faintly sweet, must be boiled within hours before bitterness sets in, the flesh should yield like young daikon, with a clean vegetal snap.

Taro

里芋 · さといも

satoimo / KŌ 49

Beneath its rough, hairy skin lies flesh so dense with starch it becomes almost custard-like when simmered, releasing a faint earthiness that clings to the teeth.

Taro

里芋 · さといも

satoimo / KŌ 52

These small, hairy corms yield flesh so starchy it becomes almost glutinous when simmered, coating the tongue with an earthy sweetness that clings.

Corn

玉蜀黍 · ともろこし

tomorokoshi / KŌ 36

Freshly harvested ears possess a milky sweetness that fades within hours of picking, the kernels so tender they burst against the teeth with grassy, almost floral notes.

01 / Young corn

01 Young corn

とうもろこし

tomorokoshi / KŌ 32

Harvested before the kernels fully set, young corn offers a milky sweetness and tender cob you can eat whole, the silk still pale, the husk tight with morning dew.

02 Malabar spinach

蔓紫 · つるむらさき

tsuru-murasaki / KŌ 41

A climbing vine whose thick, glossy leaves release a gentle mucilage when cooked, lending a cooling slip to summer dishes that cuts through the season's heaviness.

02 / Malabar spinach

Vegetables

Malabar spinach

蔓紫 · つるむらさき

tsurumurasaki / KŌ 44

A climbing vine whose heart-shaped leaves release a subtle mucilage when cut, lending body to clear soups and a cooling slickness against the August heat.

01 Winter melon

冬瓜 · とうがん

tōgan / KŌ 38, 41

Despite its name suggesting winter, this pale gourd reaches its prime in July and August, its translucent flesh turning almost glass-like when simmered in dashi, cooling the body from within.

01 / Winter melon

02 / Udo

02 Udo

独活 · うど

udo / KŌ 21

A tall, celery-pale stalk with a flavor caught between asparagus and fennel, prized for its crisp bite and faint bitterness that speaks of wild places.

Wakame

若布 · わかめ

wakame / KŌ 22

Freshly harvested wakame has a silken texture and bright mineral sweetness that fades within hours of leaving the sea, nothing like its dried counterpart.

Sweet corn

玉蜀黍 · とうもろこし

tōmorokoshi / KŌ 39, 42

Harvested at dawn and rushed to market, the kernels still hold their milk-sweet juice, bite through the taut skin and the sugars haven't yet begun their slow turn to starch.

Okra

オクラ

okura / KŌ 37

Cut crosswise, each pod reveals a perfect five-pointed star, its mucilaginous threads binding dashi and soy into something cool and slippery against the August heat.

Vegetables

01 / Tomato

01 Tomato

蕃茄 · とまと

tomato / KŌ 37

At peak ripeness, the flesh gives way to a balance of sweetness and faint acidity, the skin still warm from the afternoon heat.

Green pepper

ピーマン

piiman / KŌ 37

Summer-harvested specimens have thin, yielding walls and a clean vegetal bitterness that children famously protest and adults come to crave, char them quickly over high flame until the skin blisters and the flesh turns silken.

Molokhia

モロヘイヤ

moroheiya / KŌ 39, 42

An Egyptian mallow whose dark, almost jade leaves release a silken mucilage when chopped, thickening soups with a vegetal richness that clings to the spoon.

Water spinach

空芯菜 · くうしんさい

kūshinai / KŌ 39, 42

Named for its hollow stems that stay crisp even after a flash in the wok, this Southeast Asian green thrives in Japan's muggy July and August, offering a texture between spinach and morning glory vine.

02 Cucumber

胡瓜 · きゅうり

kyūri / KŌ 37

Sliced thin and dressed with nothing more than salt and rice vinegar, the summer cucumber offers a clean snap and faint grassy sweetness that cuts through the weight of humid days.

02 / Cucumber

Myoga ginger

茗荷 · みょうが

myōga / KŌ 39, 42

The pale pink buds emerge from shaded soil with a clean, resinous bite that cuts through summer's heaviness, sliced fine into cold sōmen or scattered over chilled tofu.

Fish & seafood

Horse mackerel

鯵 · あじ

aji / KŌ 30, 34, 44, 45

A silver-skinned fish with a clean, faintly sweet flesh that carries none of the heaviness of fattier blue fish, at its peak now, the meat firms up and develops a bright mineral finish perfect for tataki or sashimi with grated ginger.

Conger eel

穴子 · あなご

anago / KŌ 31, 32, 34, 35, 36

Unlike its richer cousin unagi, anago offers a delicate, almost ephemeral sweetness, its pale flesh turning silky when simmered in a light soy broth or brushed with nikiri and torched atop sushi.

01 Sweetfish

鮎 · あゆ

ayu / KŌ 29, 31, 32

A slender river fish whose flesh carries the faint fragrance of watermelon and fresh cucumber, the result of feeding on algae from clean mountain streams.

01 / Sweetfish

02 Bonito

鰹 · かつお

katsuo / KŌ 24

The first bonito of the season, called hatsugatsuo, arrives lean and clean-fleshed, its deep red meat best eaten as tataki, seared over straw fire until the edges char while the center stays cool and raw.

02 / Bonito

Fish & seafood

Bonito

鰹 · かつお

katsuo / KŌ 25

The spring bonito, called hatsu-gatsuo, runs lean and firm with a clean, almost metallic brightness that sashimi lovers prize for its lack of fattiness.

Conger eel

穴子 · あなご

anago / KŌ 38, 40

Anago offers a gentler, more delicate sweetness than its cousin unagi, its flesh turning silken when brushed with sweet soy and kissed by charcoal flame.

01 / Conger eel

01 Conger eel

穴子 · あなご

anago / KŌ 33

Unlike its richer cousin unagi, anago offers a lighter, more delicate sweetness, its pale flesh turns silken when simmered in sweet soy, draped warm over sushi rice in Edomae style.

02 Flounder

鰈 · かれい

karei / KŌ 24

A flatfish whose paper-thin sashimi reveals an almost translucent sweetness, the meat gaining density and fat as winter deepens.

02 / Flounder

Fish & seafood

Grunt
石鯛 · いしだい

ishidai / KŌ 27

The striped beakfish, called ishidai for its habit of crushing shellfish against stones, yields firm white flesh with a clean mineral sweetness prized in sashimi and usuzukuri.

Pike conger
鱧 · はも

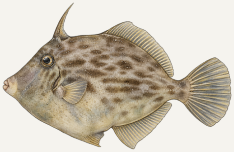
hamo / KŌ 31, 32, 41

A serpentine eel prized in Kyoto despite the sea being hours away, its flesh stays firm in summer heat, and skilled knife work transforms hundreds of hairline bones into something that blooms like a white flower when blanched.

01 Filefish
皮剥 · かわはぎ

kawahagi / KŌ 55

A fish whose rough, sandpaper skin must be stripped away to reveal meat so clean and mild it borders on sweetness, its liver swelling rich and creamy as waters chill.



01 / Filefish

Goby
鯊 · はぜ

haze / KŌ 54

A small, bottom-dwelling fish with translucent flesh that turns pure white when cooked, prized for its clean sweetness and delicate texture in tempura, the batter barely there, the fish tasting of cold river and sea meeting.

Olive flounder
鮃 · ひらめ

hirame / KŌ 55

A left-eyed flatfish prized for its translucent white flesh, served as usuzukuri, slices so thin they reveal the pattern of the plate beneath, each piece offering a clean, faintly sweet resistance to the teeth.

02 / Atka mackerel

02 Atka mackerel
ほっけ

hokke / KŌ 54

A fish of the northern seas, hokke yields pale, fatty meat that caramelizes beautifully when dried and grilled, its edges crisping while the flesh stays moist and faintly sweet.

Fish & seafood

01 / Horse mackerel

Horse mackerel

鯵 · あじ

aji / KŌ 33

A silver-sided fish with a distinctive row of bony scutes along its lateral line, aji at its peak carries a clean sweetness and firm flesh that needs nothing more than a squeeze of ginger and scallion as tataki or namero.

02 Firefly squid

蛍烏賊 · ほたるいか

hotaru ika / KŌ 23

These thumb-sized squid rise from deep waters to spawn, their photophores glowing an ethereal blue-white, eaten whole, their bodies burst with a briny sweetness and faint bitterness from the viscera.

02 / Firefly squid

Chicken grunt

伊佐木 · いさき

isaki / KŌ 28, 34, 35

A handsome striped fish whose flesh reaches its richest state just before spawning, firm yet yielding, with a clean sweetness that needs only salt and flame.

Striped beakfish

石鯛 · いしだい

ishidai / KŌ 26

A powerful reef fish with a parrot-like beak and bold black stripes that fade with age, its firm white flesh carries a clean, faintly sweet taste prized for sashimi, the texture dense enough to resist the teeth before yielding.

Fish & seafood

01 Sardine

鰯 · いわし

iwashi / KŌ 30

The silvery skin flashes blue-green like oil on water, and the meat beneath runs dark and rich with the fat that will carry the fish through lean months.

01 / Sardine

Japanese sea bass

鱸 · すずき

suzuki / KŌ 50

A sleek predator with translucent white flesh that firms beautifully when blanched and shocked in ice water, the classic arai preparation that defines summer eating.

Skipjack tuna

戻り鰹 · もどりがつお

modori-gatsuo / KŌ 49

The returning run yields flesh rich with fat from months of feeding in northern seas, deep crimson, almost burgundy, with a sweetness that needs only a whisper of ginger and ponzu.

Thread-sail filefish

皮剥 · かわはぎ

kawahagi / KŌ 43

The lean white flesh is almost transparent, mild to the point of sweetness, but it is the liver, creamy, rich as foie gras, tinged faintly orange, that devotees prize, mashed into soy sauce as a dipping medium for the sashimi.

Golden-eye snapper

金目鯛 · きんめだい

kinmedai / KŌ 51

A deep-sea fish with luminous crimson skin and large golden eyes, prized for flesh that turns silken and sweet when simmered in soy and ginger.

02 / Splendid alfonsino

02 Splendid alfonsino

金目鯛 · きんめだい

kinmedai / KŌ 56

A deep-sea fish with luminous golden eyes and rose-pink skin, its flesh turns silken and sweet when simmered in soy and mirin, the fat melting into the braising liquid.

Fish & seafood

Japanese whiting

鱚 · きす

kisu / KŌ 28

A slender, silver-skinned fish whose flesh is so delicate and clean-tasting it seems to dissolve on the tongue, the definitive tempura fish, its light sweetness heightened by a whisper-thin batter.

Japanese whiting

鱚 · きす

kisu / KŌ 29

A slender, silver-skinned fish with flesh so delicate and clean it seems to hold the lightness of early summer itself, the classic tempura-dane, its fillets curling golden in the oil while staying sweet and faintly briny within.

01 / Japanese whiting

01 Japanese whiting

鱚 · きす

kisu / KŌ 30

A slender silver fish with flesh so delicate it seems to dissolve on the tongue, prized for tempura where its clean sweetness emerges through the lightest batter.

Gizzard shad

小鰭 · こはだ

kohada / KŌ 46

A slender silver fish whose skin shimmers with an iridescent blue-green sheen, kohada is prized for its delicate balance of rich oils and clean brine, the vinegar cure of edomae sushi tradition draws out its brightness without masking the sea.

02 Japanese tiger prawn

車海老 · くるまえび

kuruma-ebi / KŌ 45

Named for the striped wheel-like pattern that curves along its shell, this prawn offers flesh that is sweet, firm, and faintly translucent, prized raw as odori, still quivering, or graced by the lightest tempura batter.

02 / Japanese tiger prawn

Japanese tiger prawn

車海老 · くるまえび

kuruma-ebi / KŌ 43

Named for the striped wheel-like pattern that curves along its shell, this prawn offers flesh that is sweet, firm, and faintly translucent, prized raw as odori, still quivering, or graced by the lightest tempura batter.

Fish & seafood

Mackerel

鯖 · さば

saba / KŌ 53

The autumn mackerel carries a stripe of silver-blue iridescence and flesh so rich with oil it glistens when sliced for shimesaba.

01 Pacific saury

秋刀魚 · さんま

sanma / KŌ 47, 50, 52, 53

A slender, steel-blue fish whose rich flesh turns sweet and oily in September, best eaten simply salted and grilled until the skin blisters and the fat sizzles onto the coals below.

01 / Pacific saury

Returning bonito

戻り鰹 · もどりがつお

modori-gatsuo / KŌ 50

These bonito have spent summer feeding in cold Sanriku seas and now carry twice the fat of their spring selves, flesh dark as aged wood, rich enough to eat as sashimi with nothing but a whisper of ginger and ponzu.

Mackerel

鯖 · さば

saba / KŌ 51

The blue-green shimmer of its skin gives way to rich, oily meat that practically melts against the tongue, autumn saba carries a depth of flavor that leaner summer fish cannot match.

02 Salmon

鮭 · さけ

sake / KŌ 48

Wild salmon arriving in autumn carry the deep coral flesh and clean fat of fish that have journeyed thousands of miles to spawn.

02 / Salmon

Salmon

秋鮭 · あきさけ

aki-sake / KŌ 52

These salmon return from the Sea of Okhotsk to their birth rivers just as the maple leaves begin to turn, their flesh leaner and cleaner than spring-caught fish, prized for its firm texture in dishes like chanko-nabe or simply salted and grilled until the skin blisters.

Fish & seafood

Salmon

鮭 · さけ

sake / KŌ 53

The flesh deepens to a ruddy coral as autumn salmon return from the sea, their fat reserves at their richest before the spawning run, this is when the belly meat yields that particular silken texture prized for grilling with nothing but salt.

Pacific saury

秋刀魚 · さんま

sanma / KŌ 43, 44, 45, 46, 48, 49, 51, 56

A slender, silver-blue fish whose belly fat reaches its richest point as September nights grow crisp, grilled whole over charcoal until the skin blisters and crackles, eaten with a squeeze of sudachi and grated daikon to cut the oils.

Sardine

鰯 · いわし

iwashi / KŌ 47

The flesh turns richly oiled as waters warm, each small silver body firm enough to eat as sashimi yet soft enough to dissolve into tsumire fish cakes.

01 / Spanish mackerel

01 Spanish mackerel

鰆 · さわら

sawara / KŌ 22, 23, 54, 55, 56

A long, silver-blue predator whose flesh turns from pale coral to creamy white when salted overnight and grilled until the skin blisters and chars at the edges, releasing oils that taste of the sea's own sweetness.

02 Halfbeak

鱵 · さより

sayori / KŌ 21, 22

A slender, silver-blue fish whose translucent flesh carries the faintest sweetness, prized for sashimi that gleams like morning light on still water.

02 / Halfbeak

Mahi-mahi

鰭 · しいら

shiira / KŌ 46

A muscular, iridescent fish whose firm white flesh takes well to the grill, yielding a clean sweetness with none of the heaviness of fattier catches.

Fish & seafood

01 Freshwater clam

蜆 · しじみ

shijimi / KŌ 41

These small, dark-shelled clams yield a broth of surprising depth, faintly sweet, touched with iron, the color of weak tea.

01 / Freshwater clam

Icefish

白魚 · しらうお

shirauo / KŌ 21, 22, 23

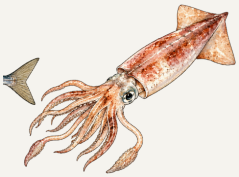
These slender, glass-clear fish arrive when winter loosens its grip, their flesh so translucent you can see the dark thread of their spines.

Spanish mackerel

鰆 · さわら

sawara / KŌ 52

The sawara's flesh is pale and delicate, with a clean sweetness that takes well to Saikyo-miso curing, the white miso paste blooming into caramel edges under the broiler.



02 / Squid

02 Squid

烏賊 · いか

ika / KŌ 40

The flesh of summer squid is firm yet yielding, its sweetness clean as sea spray, best shown in sashimi cut so thin light passes through.

Japanese sea bass

鱸 · すずき

suzuki / KŌ 41, 44

A fish that grows into its name, called different things at different sizes, finally earning 'suzuki' only when its flesh turns firm and clean, with a sweetness that takes well to a brief sear or thin-sliced as sashimi.

Japanese sea bass

鱸 · すずき

suzuki / KŌ 28, 29, 35, 36

A fish that changes names as it grows, seigo, fukko, then finally suzuki, its flesh at summer peak is clean and sweet, firm enough to hold its shape in usuzukuri slices yet yielding a delicate fat that blooms on the tongue.

Fish & seafood

Sweetfish

鮎 · あゆ

ayu / KŌ 38

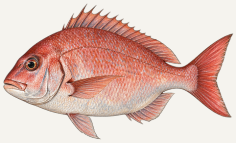
A slender, elegant river fish whose flesh carries the faint fragrance of watermelon and fresh cucumber, the scent of the algae it grazes from sun-warmed stones.

Sweetfish

鮎 · あゆ

ayu / KŌ 25, 26, 27, 33

A slender river fish whose flesh carries the faint fragrance of watermelon and fresh cucumber, the scent of clean mountain streams translated into protein.



01 / Sea bream

01 Sea bream

鯛 · たい

tai / KŌ 21, 48, 49

The firm, translucent flesh carries a clean sweetness that intensifies as spawning season approaches, the skin crisping to a burnished rose when salt-grilled.

02 Octopus

蛸 · たこ

tako / KŌ 36

Summer tako yields firm, resilient flesh with a clean sweetness that snaps between the teeth, boiled just until the skin turns that distinctive burgundy, sliced thin for sunomono or simmered tender in oden.

02 / Octopus

Yellowtail amberjack

鰤 · ぶり

buri / KŌ 40

The winter buri, called kan-buri, carries ribbons of rich fat between its rosy flesh, each slice gleaming with an almost sweet unctuousness that coats the tongue.

Greater amberjack

間八 · かんぱち

kanpachi / KŌ 47

Named for the dark band between its eyes that forms the kanji for 'eight' (□), kanpachi yields flesh that is leaner and more delicate than its buri cousins, pale pink, with a clean sweetness and subtle crunch when sliced for sashimi.

Fish & seafood

Japanese sea bass

鱸 · すずき

suzuki / KŌ 37, 42

A sleek predator with firm, translucent flesh that carries a clean sweetness, prized now for arai, ice-chilled sashimi slices that tighten into a texture both yielding and crisp.

01 Beltfish

太刀魚 · たちうお

tachiuo / KŌ 42

Named for its resemblance to a Japanese sword, the tachiuo is a ribbon of silver that swims vertically in deep waters, its flesh turning translucent and sweet as autumn deepens.

01 / Beltfish

Conger eel

穴子 · あなご

anago / KŌ 37, 39

Anago offers a gentler, more delicate sweetness than its cousin unagi, its flesh turning silken when brushed with sweet soy and kissed by charcoal flame.

02 / Abalone

02 Abalone

鮑 · あわび

awabi / KŌ 39

The muscular foot, sliced thin against its grain, yields a clean brine and a crunch that softens to velvet, prized raw as sashimi or barely kissed by steam.

Horse mackerel

鯵 · あじ

aji / KŌ 42

A silver-skinned fish with a clean, faintly sweet flesh that carries none of the heaviness of fattier blue fish, at its peak now, the meat firms up and develops a bright mineral finish perfect for tataki or sashimi with grated ginger.

Pike conger

鱧 · はも

hamo / KŌ 37, 39

A serpentine eel with a jaw full of fine bones, requiring the hamo-giri knife technique, hundreds of precise cuts that transform danger into silk, the flesh blooming white when blanched and dressed with tart umeboshi.

Season key

CANONICAL KO IDS / APPROXIMATE START DATES

01 Water parsley flourishes
芹乃栄 01/05 · winter

02 Springs thaw beneath the ice
水泉動 01/10 · winter

03 Pheasants start to call
雉始雊 01/15 · winter

04 Butterburs bud
款冬華 01/20 · winter

05 Ice thickens on streams
水沢腹堅 01/25 · winter

06 Hens start laying eggs
鶏始乳 01/30 · winter

07 East wind melts the ice
東風解凍 02/04 · spring

08 Bush warblers start singing in the mountains
黄鶯睍睆 02/09 · spring

09 Fish emerge from the ice
魚上氷 02/14 · spring

10 Rain moistens the soil
土脈潤起 02/19 · spring

11 Mist starts to linger
霞始靆 02/24 · spring

12 Plants sprout, trees bud
草木萌動 03/01 · spring

13 Hibernating insects emerge
蟄虫啓戸 03/06 · spring

14 First peach blossoms open
桃始笑 03/11 · spring

15 Caterpillars become butterflies
菜虫化蝶 03/16 · spring

16 Sparrows start nesting
雀始巣 03/21 · spring

17 First cherry blossoms
桜始開 03/26 · spring

18 Distant thunder
雷乃発声 03/31 · spring

19 Swallows arrive
玄鳥至 04/05 · spring

20 Wild geese fly north
鴻雁北 04/10 · spring

21 First rainbows appear
虹始見 04/15 · spring

22 First reeds sprout
葭始生 04/20 · spring

23 Last frost, rice shoots sprout
霜止出苗 04/25 · spring

24 Peonies bloom
牡丹華 04/30 · spring

DATES VARY SLIGHTLY BY YEAR / GLOSSARY REFERENCES SOURCE LETTERS

Season key

CANONICAL KO IDS / APPROXIMATE START DATES

25 Frogs start calling
蛙始鳴 05/06 · summer

26 Earthworms emerge
蚯蚓出 05/11 · summer

27 Bamboo shoots appear
竹笋生 05/16 · summer

28 Silkworms feast on mulberry leaves
蚕起食桑 05/21 · summer

29 Safflowers bloom
紅花栄 05/26 · summer

30 Wheat ripens and harvest begins
麦秋至 05/31 · summer

31 Praying mantises hatch
螳螂生 06/06 · summer

32 Decaying grass becomes fireflies
腐草為蛍 06/11 · summer

33 Plums turn yellow
梅子黄 06/16 · summer

34 Self-heal withers
乃東枯 06/21 · summer

35 Irises bloom
菖蒲華 06/26 · summer

36 Crow-dipper sprouts
半夏生 07/02 · summer

37 Warm winds arrive
温風至 07/07 · summer

38 Lotus blossoms open
蓮始開 07/12 · summer

39 Young hawks learn to fly
鷹乃学習 07/17 · summer

40 Paulownia trees bear first seeds
桐始結花 07/23 · summer

41 Humid heat soaks the earth
土潤溽暑 07/28 · summer

42 Heavy rains sometimes fall
大雨時行 08/02 · summer

43 Cool winds arrive
涼風至 08/07 · autumn

44 Evening cicadas sing
寒蝉鳴 08/12 · autumn

45 Thick fog descends
蒙霧升降 08/17 · autumn

46 Cotton flowers open
綿柎開 08/23 · autumn

47 Heaven and earth begin to cool
天地始粛 08/28 · autumn

48 Rice ripens in the fields
禾乃登 09/02 · autumn

DATES VARY SLIGHTLY BY YEAR / GLOSSARY REFERENCES SOURCE LETTERS

Season key

CANONICAL KO IDS / APPROXIMATE START DATES

49 Dew glistens white on grass
草露白 09/08 · autumn

50 Wagtails start to sing
鶺鴒鳴 09/13 · autumn

51 Swallows depart
玄鳥去 09/18 · autumn

52 Thunder falls silent
雷乃収声 09/23 · autumn

53 Insects seal their dens
蟄虫坏戸 09/28 · autumn

54 Water begins to dry up
水始涸 10/03 · autumn

55 Wild geese arrive from the north
鴻雁来 10/08 · autumn

56 Chrysanthemums bloom
菊花開 10/13 · autumn

57 Crickets chirp around the door
蟋蟀在戸 10/18 · autumn

58 First frost falls
霜始降 10/23 · autumn

59 Light rains sometimes fall
霎時施 10/28 · autumn

60 Maple and ivy turn yellow
楓蔦黄 11/02 · autumn

61 Camellias start to bloom
山茶始開 11/07 · winter

62 Earth begins to freeze
地始凍 11/12 · winter

63 Daffodils bloom and perfume the air
金盞香 11/17 · winter

64 Rainbows hide
虹蔵不見 11/22 · winter

65 North winds blow away the leaves
朔風払葉 11/27 · winter

66 Tachibana citrus starts to ripen
橘始黄 12/02 · winter

67 Skies close and winter sets in
閉塞成冬 12/07 · winter

68 Bears retreat to their dens
熊蟄穴 12/12 · winter

69 Salmon gather and swim upstream
鰤魚群 12/17 · winter

70 Self-heal sprouts anew
乃東生 12/22 · winter

71 Deer shed their antlers
麋角解 12/27 · winter

72 Wheat sprouts under the snow
雪下出麦 01/01 · winter

DATES VARY SLIGHTLY BY YEAR / GLOSSARY REFERENCES SOURCE LETTERS